The international context at the beginning of the twenty-first century was, at first, one of continued unipolarity, even if signs of trouble began to surface. American technology dominance overshadowed the steady growth of emerging economies. It was perhaps this that led the US to underestimate China's potential for rapid economic growth and amazing exploitation of trade opportunities. The conflict in Yugoslavia provided an opportunity to once again stamp the authority of Western powers, oblivious to the long-term threats that would hit them soon. It was not surprising that during this period, India-US relations developed well and sought to put behind issues that constrained their growth.

The Kargil experience enhanced confidence levels between them and the awkwardly titled 'Next Steps in Strategic Partnership (NSSP)' followed thereafter in 2004 to address export-control restrictions more positively. In the aftermath of the 2005 Indo-US nuclear deal, this appears less bold than it was at the time. But it provided a vital step towards attempting a larger breakthrough on the nuclear issue. In-between, there was a sea change in the global setting with the September 11 attacks and an American return to Afghanistan. India's handling of this opportunity was skilful, and it positioned itself as a sympathetic but understanding partner willing to work to American comfort levels. In the US itself, the Indian community grew steadily as a result of the H-1B programme and acquired the ability to make its interest felt in US politics. Terrorism and tech were the two drivers of the transformation of Indo-US relations that, in turn, opened up new vistas for India. In both cases, the Indian government's adeptness at seizing the opportunity is as important to recognize as the significance of the events themselves.

Even as India embarked on ground-breaking initiatives with the US, it sought to balance that with progress on other important accounts. The initiation of the Russia-India-China grouping (RIC) in 2001 that was to provide the nucleus for BRICS was one such step. The invention of the Special Representatives mechanism on boundary negotiations with China in 2003 was another. This was taken forward with the 2005 Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles on the boundary issue that promised a forward movement. There was briefly even serious talk of a free trade agreement with China. Relations with France, which showed more